

6.1b

An introduction to report writing

Worksheet

5 The language of report writing

5.1 Linking words

Sentences and paragraphs need linking words to help the reader understand the structure of the argument. For example:

<i>First, ... Second, ... Finally, ...</i>	a sequence
<i>Moreover, ... / In addition to this, ...</i>	adding another, related idea
<i>However, ... / On the other hand, ...</i>	a contrast
<i>... due to ... / Therefore, ...</i>	cause and result

Linking words can also be used to show a personal attitude. For example, if you begin a sentence with the word *Clearly*, what comes next will be obvious. If you begin with the word *Apparently*, you are indicating that you are uncertain of your facts.

5.2 Formal language

Most business writing is neutral and direct rather than formal. Three areas of grammar are useful when a more formal, impersonal style is needed. They are:

- The passive *A decision is expected by the end of the year.
20,000 new jobs were created in the financial sector last year.
The final payment will be made in September.*
- 'It' + passive *It is recommended that we reduce the training budget by 10%.
It should be emphasized that this data is only provisional.
It was suggested/agreed that we use a different supplier.*
- Compound nouns *a planning meeting; a production planning meeting
the sales conference; the summer sales conference
insurance documents; transport insurance documents*

Formal language like this is only used when it makes the report easier to understand. For example, in the second example above we do not know who created the jobs, so the passive is better. Similarly, in the sixth example it is not important who made the suggestion, so the passive is better. Compound nouns avoid the use of long phrases full of prepositions: 'a meeting about the planning of our production'.

5.3 Informal language

Contractions like *It's*, *we'll*, *there's* and words and phrases typical of informal speech like *big*, *OK*, *nice*, *no way*, *fantastic* should not appear in reports.

6 Conclusion

Reports can be about many things: an analysis of a problem, a summary of a completed job, the progress of a project, the results of an investigation. There are few general rules, but remember that organizing the material into logical sections is the key. Finally, remember also that the reader will be very busy, so be as brief and clear as possible.

B Choose one of the topics below and write a mini-report.

- Summary/evaluation of a newspaper/magazine article.
- Summary/evaluation of this course up to now.
- Summary/evaluation of a recent meeting/negotiation (in real life or on this course).
- Report writing in my job (types of report, objectives, audience, preparation, content etc.).
- Opportunities for tourism in my country.